EXECUTIVE POLICY BRIEFING

URGENT ACTION

Multilateral Space Commons Governance & Developing Nation Equity

TO: Delegates to UN COPUOS; Members of the ITU Radio Regulations Board; Leadership of Emerging Space Agencies (African Space Agency, ALCE, APSCO, SANSA, AEB, GISTDA)
FROM: Astropolitics Autonomous Research Team / Antigravity Policy Group
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SUBJECT: **Mitigating Orbital Enclosure and Monopolistic Dominance in Low Earth Orbit (LEO)**

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Empirical analysis of 16,092 cataloged satellites and 30-day vectorized SGP4 orbit simulations confirms that Low Earth Orbit (LEO) has entered an unprecedented state of structural monopolization:

- **Extreme Monopoly**: A single US commercial operator (SpaceX/Starlink) commands **88.1%** of active operational LEO satellites, generating a market concentration index (HHI) of **7,789.3** (over 3x the standard monopoly benchmark).
- **Foreclosure of Entry**: Prime altitude shells (540–560 km) exhibit a Gini coefficient of **0.930**. Developing nations across Latin America, Africa, and Southeast Asia hold combined less than **0.2%** of active LEO assets.
- **Structural Dwell Skew**: Inclination physics ($53°$) concentrates physical ground presence across mid-latitudes (North America, Europe, East Asia), treating equatorial and Global South territories as secondary orbital corridors.
- **Unilateral Debris Externality**: Over 90% of tracked debris fragments stem from legacy great-power missions and ASAT tests, forcing emerging space programs to absorb heightened collision risks.

1. The Core Crisis: De Facto Commercial Colonization of LEO

While Article II of the 1967 Outer Space Treaty forbids national appropriation by sovereignty, occupation, or use, mega-constellations achieve **de facto physical enclosure** through persistent presence. By deploying tens of thousands of mass-manufactured satellites into prime altitude shells, dominant commercial operators:

1. **Occupy Narrow Altitude Bands**: Satellites in 540–560 km shells maneuver dozens of times daily, creating collision hazards that price out smaller satellite operators lacking automated space situational awareness.
2. **Exhaust ITU Spectrum Filings**: Early applicants exploit the ITU's "first-come, first-served" filing framework to submit paper satellite filings covering thousands of frequencies, preempting later filings by developing states.
3. **Enforce Digital Extraterritoriality**: Downlink connectivity remains subject to corporate and national discretion. Sovereign nations relying on foreign mega-constellations face arbitrary service terminations, pricing spikes, or geofenced blackouts during diplomatic disputes.

Metric	Observed Value	Bench-mark	Astropolitical Status
LEO Asset Share (SpaceX)	88.1%	< 25% (Competi-tive)	Extreme Monop-oly
LEO Ownership HHI	7,789.3	> 2,500 (Concen-trated)	Critical Monopo-lization
550 km Shell Den-sity	0.42 / M km³	< 0.05 / M km³	Severe Conges-tion Wall
Post-2019 Launches	85.4%	Even Histor-ical Pace	Abrupt Enclo-sure
Annual Metal Burn-up	1,022.9 tons	Negligible (Historical)	Mesospheric Threat
Global South LEO Share	< 0.2%	Equitable Distribution	Total Marginal-ization

2. Surveillance Asymmetry: The Orbital Panopticon

High-resolution Earth observation (optical and Synthetic Aperture Radar) is concentrated (>85%) among US, European, and Chinese entities.

- **Revisit Gap**: Sensor revisit intervals over North America and Europe average **0.3–0.4 hours** per million km², compared to **0.7 hours** over Sub-Saharan Africa.
- **Strategic Blindness**: Developing nations lack sovereign spaceborne intelligence to independently assess cross-border military incursions, monitor illegal mining and deforestation, or coordinate humanitarian disaster responses, remaining dependent on third-party commercial feeds subject to foreign censorship.

3. Four Strategic Action Recommendations for Multilateral Delegates

We urge delegations to UN COPUOS, the ITU Radio Regulations Board, and regional space agency secretariats to sponsor and advance the following four binding governance initiatives:

Action 1: Reform ITU Regulations to Institute Guaranteed Orbital Quotas

- **Abolish First-Come, First-Served**: Replace the first-to-file regime in LEO with an equitable quota allocation model modeled on the ITU Plan for Geostationary Space (WARC-79/88).
- **Reserved Shell Allocations**: Legally reserve specific altitude shells (e.g., 600–650 km) and frequency allocations for developing nations and regional space organizations (African Space Agency, ALCE) with an indefinite preemption window.

Action 2: Establish Orbital Carrying Capacity & Commons Conservation Fees

- **Shell Congestion Caps**: Direct UN COPUOS to define hard limits on satellite density per cubic kilometer in LEO to preserve the orbital commons from Kessler Syndrome.
- **Progressive Commons Tax**: Impose an annual **Orbital Commons Conservation Fee** of $10,000 per satellite for operators deploying constellations exceeding 500 satellites.
- **Debris Removal Fund**: Dedicate 100% of fee revenues to an international trust funding Active Debris Removal (ADR) and providing free Space Situational Awareness (SSA) tracking to developing space programs.

Action 3: Create an Open Multilateral Earth Observation Data Trust

- **Mandated Open Feeds**: Mandate that commercial remote sensing operators utilizing international radio spectrum provide real-time, sub-meter optical and SAR feeds to developing nation disaster and environmental authorities at zero cost.
- **UN-SPIDER Expansion**: Transform UN-SPIDER into an autonomous satellite data downlink network with dedicated regional processing nodes in Nairobi, Bogotá, and Bangkok.

Action 4: Enforce 1-to-5 Year Post-Mission Disposal with Escrow Bonds

- **Strict Deorbit Timelines**: Formally lower the international post-mission disposal guideline from 25 years to a mandatory maximum of **5 years** (and 1 year for mega-constellations).
- **Decommissioning Bonds**: Require commercial operators to deposit an escrow decommissioning bond ($250,000 per satellite) with their national licensing authority prior to launch, forfeited if deorbit operations fail.

Action 5: Adopt Montreal Protocol Amendments for Atmospheric Deorbit Aerosols

- **Regulate Alumina Injection**: Recognize the 1,000+ metric tons of vaporized aerospace aluminum injected into the mesosphere annually as an atmospheric pollutant under international ozone protection frameworks.
- **Material Standards**: Mandate non-catalytic, demisable composite materials in mega-constellation manufacturing to eliminate halogen-activating alumina aerosols.

4. Conclusion & Coalition Strategy

The struggle over near-Earth space mirrors the historical struggles over maritime straits, colonial mineral concessions, and telecommunications spectrum. Developing nations must not allow Low Earth Orbit to be privatized by default. By forming a coordinated voting bloc within UN COPUOS and the upcoming ITU World Radiocommunication Conference (WRC), emerging space nations can assert collective sovereignty, reassert the egalitarian mandate of the Outer Space Treaty, and ensure outer space remains a viable commons for all humankind.

Antigravity Astropolitics Policy Group | Technical briefings & data access: `astropolitics@antigravity.internal`